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ASOR ANNUAL MEETING (/AM/)

Mount Zion – Female Union Band Society Cemetery Documentation Event



Ever wanted to learn the art of preserving history? Curious about the stories etched in the stones of local cemeteries? Here's your chance to dive into the fascinating world of cemetery documentation!

The Mount Zion – Female Union Band Society Cemetery (<https://www.mtzion-fubs.org/history>) is a historic cemetery located in the Georgetown neighborhood of Washington, D.C. The three-acre cemetery is composed of two roughly equal-sized halves, the Mount Zion Cemetery on the east and the Female Union Band Society Cemetery on the west, separated along a subtle north-south ridge in the center of the property.

Historically called the Old Methodist Burying Ground, the cemetery originated as a churchyard burial ground. It was established by the Montgomery Street Methodist Church in 1808, which gathered at the Montgomery Street Meeting House, formerly located on Twenty-Eighth Street between M and Olive Streets, N.W. (formerly Montgomery Street between Bridge and Olive Streets), approximately one-half mile southwest of the cemetery. The Montgomery Street Methodist Church was one of the few churches at the time that accepted white and black members, though on a segregated basis. Nearly half of the congregation consisted of former slaves and free blacks in the years leading up to 1816, when a group of 125 black members, dissatisfied with segregation, established their own congregation under the supervision of the parent church.

The congregation, now called the Mount Zion United Methodist Church and located at 1334 Twenty-Ninth Street, N.W., is thought to be the oldest black congregation in the District of Columbia, as well as the first black Methodist church in the area. The cemetery is the only remaining in D.C. used to inter a significant number of former slaves.

On October 19, 1842, a tract of land along the western border of the Old Methodist Burying Ground was sold for \$250 to Joseph Mason in trust for the Female Union Band Society, a cooperative benevolent society founded in the same year by a group of free African American and Native American women. The Female Union Band Society purchased the western lot of Mount Zion to establish a secular burying ground for African Americans, which remained a prominent cemetery for the region's African American community until 1950.

Continue reading the full history of the cemetery here (https://www.mtzion-fubs.org/_files/ugd/2da97a_45420bf9c78a4aec90e2c2d7d9ccc102.pdf).

Black Georgetown Foundation (<https://www.mtzion-fubs.org/>), **Archaeology in the Community (AITC)** (<https://www.archaeologyincommunity.com/>) & the **American Society of Overseas Research (ASOR)** (<https://www.asor.org/>) are proud to host a free 3-day hybrid workshop on cemetery documentation.

 Dates: June 27, 29, & 30, 2024

 Location: Mount Zion – Female Union Band Society Cemetery, 2501 Mill Rd NW, Washington, D.C. 20007 & Via ZOOM

 **Open to the Public** – No Prior Experience Needed! Familiarity with computers is recommended, but not required.

 What to Expect:

- Guided training sessions on cemetery documentation techniques
- Hands-on experience in cataloging tombstones and historical markers
- Insights into the rich history and cultural significance of Mount Zion – Female Union Band Society Cemetery
- Opportunities to connect with fellow history enthusiasts and preservationists
- Don't miss out on this unique opportunity to contribute to the preservation of our heritage! Whether you're a seasoned historian or simply curious about the past, all are welcome to join us.

Kindly register **here** (https://www.flipcause.com/secure/cause_pdetails/MjA5NjUy) to secure your spot.

For inquiries, contact Jared Koller (jaredkoller@asor.org (<mailto:jaredkoller@asor.org>)).

Let's come together to honor the past and pave the way for future generations to cherish and learn from the legacies of the Mount Zion – Female Union Band Society Cemetery!

Program Schedule

Click on the session links below to view the schedule for each day.

Thursday, June 27

Introduction (#)

Saturday, June 29

Mount Zion – Female Union Band Society Cemetery (#)
Sunday, June 30

Data Processing (#)

Introduction to Heritage Documentation

THURSDAY, June 27, 2024

7:00 – 9:00pm EDT

Via Zoom

This training will introduce foundational concepts in heritage documentation for historic cemeteries:

1. Cemetery documentation fundamentals
2. Data collection: Kobotoolbox
3. Basics of Photogrammetry

KoBoToolbox (<https://www.kobotoolbox.org/>) is a free and open source software package for location and descriptive data collection. Information can be collected at heritage sites through tablets and phones using the KoBoCollect app or through the web browser interface, even when

those devices are offline. Location and descriptive data recorded in the field can then be synched up with GIS software once an internet connection has been reestablished.

Photogrammetry is the use of two dimensional (2D) images to provide measurement data. Measurement data includes the creation of 3D models for heritage documentation and preservation. Processing heritage data through photogrammetry offers a transformative lens into the past. By meticulously capturing and analyzing images, we unveil hidden dimensions of cemeteries and tombs. This method not only preserves archaeological sites digitally but also facilitates precise measurements and reconstructions, fostering deeper insights into the legacies of African Americans in the Washington D.C. area.

On-site Training at Mount Zion – Female Union Band Society Cemetery

SATURDAY, June 29, 2024

10:00am – 4:00pm EDT (Attend for as long as you wish)

2501 Mill Rd NW, Washington D.C. 20007

We will convene on Saturday at the Mount Zion – Female Union Band Society Cemetery, located in the Georgetown neighborhood of Washington, D.C. (2501 Mill Rd NW, Washington, DC 20007).

Attendees are welcome to join at any point between 10am and 4pm to gain practical experience in cemetery documentation techniques:

1. Insights into the rich history and cultural significance of Mount Zion – Female Union Band Society Cemetery
2. Hands-on experience in cataloging tombstones and historical markers using free online databases (Kobotoolbox)
3. Photographic strategies for heritage preservation

** AITC and ASOR will provide the equipment needed during the training.*

Data Processing

SUNDAY, June 30, 2024

1:00 – 4:00pm EDT

Via Zoom

On the final day of training we will process and examine the data collected at Mount Zion – Female Union Band Society Cemetery. Attendees will learn how to edit and publish their data stored in Kobotoolbox. They will also have a chance to build 3D models through photogrammetry of gravestones and tombs located at the cemetery.

BROWSE THE NEWS ARCHIVE

Fieldwork Report: Sarah “Gigi” Konecki-Brazeal (<https://www.asor.org/news/2025/03/fieldwork-report-konecki-brazeal>)

Spring Book Sale (<https://www.asor.org/news/2025/03/spring-book-sale>)

Save the Date for ASOR's 125th Anniversary Celebration (<https://www.asor.org/news/2025/03/asor-125-celebrate>)

ECS Research in Action: Rennan Lemos (<https://www.asor.org/news/2025/03/ecs-rennan-lemos>)

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